The Western powers, especially the USA, provided much of the weaponry, including Stinger missiles to shoot down Soviet helicopter gunships, while countries like Saudi Arabia encouraged many volunteers to go and fight in Afghanistan. The military intelligence services of Pakistan, Saudi Arabia, the USA and Britain trained and armed recruits to fight against the Soviet forces. One of the Saudi volunteers was Osama Bin Laden. He was the son of the owner of a large construction business in Saudi Arabia and he used his wealth and expertise to build a vast underground complex for weapons and medical facilities in Afghanistan. He also took charge of an organisation which co-ordinated the activities of the thousands of Arab Islamists fighting alongside the Afghan *mujahideen* and he established training camps or bases, the Arabic word for which is *al-Qaida*. About 15,000 volunteers from Saudi Arabia trained in these camps and several thousand were trained in Egypt to go and fight in Afghanistan. These 'Arab Afghans' became battle-hardened, experienced guerrilla fighters.

In 1989 the Soviet forces were finally forced to withdraw from Afghanistan. They had faced fierce resistance and realised they were fighting a war they could not win. The war had lasted for 10 years and cost the lives of a million Afghans. It had given rise to the growth of numerous Islamist organisations and inspired millions to believe in their powers. Many Islamist groups felt that, if they could defeat the Soviet Union, then surely they could defeat their own much weaker, unpopular Arab regimes?

Key question
How did Arab governments respond to political Islam?

The growth of political Islam

In the Arab countries, those attracted to radical, political Islam were often young, angry, educated and middle class, like engineers, doctors and scientists. Their organisations were often banned by the authorities, their activities were monitored by the security services and many were arrested. However, they thrived in the one area which the Arab governments dared not ban – in the mosques. Sermons were recorded and spread via cassettes, later by CDs and the Internet. The Islamists often established education and welfare services that were better than those provided by the State. In this way, they often won wide support.

However, some of their terrorist activities caused outrage both at home and abroad. In Egypt there was an increasing number of attacks in the mid-1990s, mostly on police officers and government officials but also on Western tourists. These activities led to a clampdown by the government in which urban areas suspected of protecting the perpetrators were attacked by helicopters and troops. This in turn led to several assassination attempts on Egyptian President Mubarak. The killing of 58 tourists in one attack in 1997 led to the execution of 60 ringleaders and the detention without trial of 20,000 people. Egypt's militant Islamists were too weak to continue their campaign after this, but some of the Islamists' demands were met with the increasing adoption of the veil by women in public and of religious law in settling disputes over marriage and divorce.